
AQA
Questions matter
A-level English Literature A Mark scheme guidance and application
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Summer 2025

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Welcome
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Course overview

This live AQA training course will provide you with guidance on how to apply the mark scheme to key questions/question types. You will have the opportunity to take part in marking activities and discussion led by a senior AQA examiner to help with preparation for 2025/26 mock marking.

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Learning outcomes

- Develop a greater understanding of how to apply the mark scheme
- Apply accuracy when identifying a level/awarding a mark
- Identify typical features and characteristics of responses at different levels/marks
- Analyse and discuss the application of mark schemes with a senior examiner to strengthen your understanding

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Session structure

1. The mark scheme
2. A closer look at the mark scheme and how to navigate
3. Applying the mark scheme to the four specification question types:
    - Single texts (closed book)
    - Single texts (open book)
    - Unseens
    - Comparing texts of different genres
4. Plenary

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General marking guidance

Introduction

A-level English Literature seeks to build on what students learned at GCSE about how writers communicate ideas about the world and how readers might respond. It extends students' critical understanding of the ways in which literary texts are constructed and the various contexts and connections which might determine how they are interpreted. A-level explores further the complexities **of how literature reflects the individual, society, history and culture.**

Philosophy

AQA A-level specifications A and B are built around different philosophies of English Literature. Specification A takes historicism (i.e. how attitudes change over time) as its primary focus, whereas Specification B chooses to focus on genre as its guiding principle.

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General marking guidance

However, the two specifications cohere around:

- five assessment objectives
- a generic mark scheme
- a commitment to holistic marking.

Whereas AQA GCSE involves four AOs and six levels of achievement, A-level involves five AOs and five bands of achievement.

The generic five-band A-level mark scheme is best considered thinking of Band 3 as being at the centre of the mark scheme, the mid-point where the student begins to answer the question clearly, expressing relevant ideas and straightforward understanding. Beyond that, answers can develop more coherent and thorough arguments culminating in confident and perceptive answers in Band 5. Below that, answers might show some simple and generalised understanding but do not develop a convincing answer to the question.

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General marking guidance

To help select the most appropriate band and position within the band, there are three useful tools to use:

- The ‘headline’ descriptors for each band (see the left-hand column of the generic grid)
- The descriptions of the middle, top and bottom achievement in each band (see the right-hand column)
- The principle of choosing a band, going to the middle of the band and then fine-tuning the best mark within the band by looking across the AOs.

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General marking guidance

Holistic marking

In AQA A-level English Literature, the five AOs are always fluid, interrelated and interdependent. They are necessary analytical components when studying literary texts and when answering questions in a satisfying and convincing fashion. It follows then that all our questions should either directly or indirectly encode the five AOs. All answers should aim to put forward a relevant interpretive argument (AO5), analysing relevant literary ways or methods (AO2) and taking account of relevant contexts (AO3) and connections (AO4). Of course, the expression of the answer (AO1) is fundamental, and it is important to recognise the primacy of AO1 in delivering the other AOs.

The AOs will be addressed, then, if the student **answers the question**. This is always the simplest and best advice to follow. If the student answers the question in a relevant and detailed way, everything will be covered.

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General marking guidance

Making holistic judgements in practice

It will help you to arrive at an accurate holistic judgement in marking your own students' work if you:

- read the whole answer first before thinking about bands or marks
- tick sparingly and judiciously where the student is answering relevantly and when you can see the student making comments that go beyond a straightforward answer
- avoid random ticking and tracking individual AOs, both of which undermine the notion of holistic marking.

When you look over the annotated script there should be a logical correlation between ticks, positive comments and the final band/mark awarded. .

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General marking guidance

The marking exercises that follow will include exemplification of Bands 2, 3, 4 and 5.

For Specification A the nine exercises are organised around comparable question types which are a feature of both Paper 1 and Paper 2:

- Single texts (closed book) – see Paper 1 Section A
- Single texts (open book) – see Paper 2 Section A
- Unseens – see Paper 1 Section B and Paper 2 Section B (first part)
- Comparing texts of different genres – see Paper 1 Section C and Paper 2 Section B (second part)

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General marking guidance

The exercises concentrate on the fact that **all** questions are marked using the **same** generic marking grid. Each question has an additional indicative content part of the mark scheme for additional guidance, but this course focuses on using the generic grid and developing familiarity and the ability to use it precisely as the primary tool.

At the same time, each of the question types has challenges that the marker should take into account:

- Single texts (closed book) – demands close reading and being able to use the wider text beyond the extract
- Single texts (open book) – needs students to select carefully from across the whole text
- Unseens – challenges students to read closely and make links within the shared context of Love through the ages, World War One and its aftermath or Modern times
- Comparing texts of different genres – requires careful choices to be made from both texts and the co-ordination of a clear, comparative approach.

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Understanding mark scheme creation and standardisation

- Mark schemes are written alongside question papers. This helps lead assessment writers to consider the assessment objectives, question stems and likely answers from students at the same time.
- They are scrutinised along with the question paper at all stages of creation; adapted and refined throughout.
- When students have sat the examination, mark schemes are often adapted further by a panel of senior examiners to reflect the way students have responded to the question set. This is part of the process of standardisation.
- Specimen papers that are created when a specification is developed or changed do not go through a standardisation process – something to keep in mind when using those assessments with students.
- The lead examiner has ultimate ownership of the mark scheme and standardisation process. The job of the examiner is to use the mark scheme to apply that standard across all scripts that they are marking.

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The purpose of a mark scheme

- Mark schemes are created to help examiners apply a set standard to the marking of scripts.
- They help us to ensure a level of consistency in marking across all learners' scripts.
- Mark schemes are developed as part of the process of accreditation by the regulator Ofqual, and in many cases the design of these is tied up in those regulations.
    - An example of this might be the way in which the 25 marks available for each question must always have five band levels looking holistically across five assessment objectives.
- Mark schemes contain information such as the question, mark tariff, assessment objectives, indicative content (in a separate section) and level marking grids. Each of these features are there to serve different purposes

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Question 1 Paper 1

This first section of Paper 1 requires a response to a taught Shakespeare text (*Othello*, *The Taming of the Shrew*, *Measure for Measure* or *The Winter's Tale*). There is no student choice as far as the question is concerned; all *Othello* students will answer Question 1, and so on.

This is a **closed-book** question where close reading is supported by reprinting an **extract** from the play. To answer the question, the student needs to address the **question focus** through the lens of the **given view** by looking closely at the **set extract** and any wider play references that might be relevant.

Confident students might be able to quote accurately from elsewhere in the play, but where there are minor inaccuracies in reference to the wider play, markers need to remember the closed–book nature of the examination and reward rather than penalise.

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Question 1 Paper 1

'In Othello, Iago's skills make him a likeable anti-hero rather than a hateful villain.'

In the light of this view, discuss how Shakespeare presents Iago's attitudes to love in this extract and elsewhere in the play.

Question focus: Iago's attitudes to love
Given view: likeable anti hero or hateful villain
Set extract: Iago manipulates the drunken Cassio into approaching Desdemona to help Cassio win his job back. Iago reveals in soliloquy how this plan will actually stoke Othello's jealous suspicions about Desdemona and help to destroy them all as his enemies.

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Activity: Question 1 Paper 1, Student A

Please see Student A's response on page 10 in the Pre-event marking booklet.

To mark the response here, concentrate on the **generic marking grid** and make an accurate **holistic** judgement:

- Consider how well the student addresses the given view and question focus.
- Consider how closely they examine the set extract.
- Decide on the 'best fit' band that applies.
- Go the middle mark, then fine tune up or down, looking across the AOs to help you.

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Activity: Question 1 Paper 1, Student B

Please see Student B's response on page 16 in the Pre-event marking booklet.

To mark the response here, concentrate on the **generic marking grid** and make an accurate **holistic** judgement:

- Consider how well the student addresses the given view and question focus.
- Consider how closely they examine the set extract.
- Decide on the 'best fit' band that applies.
- Go the middle mark, then fine tune up or down, looking across the AOs to help you.

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Activity: Question 1 Paper 1, Student C

Please see Student C's response on page 20 in the Pre-event marking booklet.

To mark the response here, concentrate on the **generic marking grid** and make an accurate **holistic** judgement:

- Consider how well the student addresses the given view and question focus.
- Consider how closely they examine the set extract.
- Decide on the 'best fit' band that applies.
- Go the middle mark, then fine tune up or down, looking across the AOs to help you.

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Question 14 Paper 2A

This first section of Paper 2 requires a response to a taught text of a particular genre (*Up the Line to Death* or *Scars Upon My Heart* for poetry; *Oh! What a Lovely War* or *Journey's End* for Drama; *Regeneration* or *Birdsong* for prose). There is student choice here – one of two questions.

This is an **open book** question where students can range across the text as appropriate and there is immediate access for close reading. To answer the question, the student needs to address the **question focus** through the lens of the **given view** by looking closely at relevant material from the text concerned.

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Question 14 Paper 2A

'In *Regeneration*, Barker suggests there is no escape from war.'

Examine this view of the novel.

Question focus: escape from the war as presented in the novel
Given view: no escape from war?

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Activity: Question 14 Paper 2A, Student D

Please see Student D's response on page 27 in the Pre-event marking booklet.

To mark the response here, concentrate on the **generic marking grid** and make an accurate **holistic** judgement:

- Consider how well the student addresses the given view and question focus.
- Consider how closely and selectively they examine the text.
- Decide on the 'best fit' band that applies.
- Go the middle mark, then fine tune up or down, looking across the AOs to help you.

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Question 11 Paper 2B

- This second section of Paper 2 requires a response to an **unseen prose text**. There is no student choice of question here. The question tests analytical skills and an understanding of the shared context, here of modern times, literature from 1945 to the present day. Some contextual information to support students is given in a preamble to the question, allowing for the fact that the extract is from a novel.
- The focus here is on an extract from an untaught text that students are unlikely to have read or even heard of. However, the shared context provides subject matters and themes that the student may recognise from their studies for this paper where they will have been taught three texts: a novel, a play and a volume of poetry.
- To answer the question, the student needs to address the **question focus** through the lens of the **given view** by looking closely at relevant material from the text. In this particular example, there is no quoted or reported view, but the word **significance**, as used elsewhere in the specification, implies a view that the question focus has meanings in the text and the student is invited to decode, explore and evaluate.

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Question 11 Paper 2B

Explore the significance of loneliness and social isolation in this extract.
(see extract from *A Trick I Learned from Dead Men* by Kitty Aldridge on page 31 of the Pre-event marking booklet).

Remember to include in your answer relevant detailed analysis of the ways that Aldridge shapes meanings.

Question focus: loneliness and social isolation
Given view: significance?

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Activity: Question 11 Paper 2B, Student E

Please see Student E's response on page 36 in the Pre-event marking booklet.

To mark the response here, concentrate on the **generic marking grid** and make an accurate **holistic** judgement:

- Consider how well the student addresses the given view and question focus.
- Consider how closely and selectively they examine the text.
- Decide on the 'best fit' band that applies.
- Go the middle mark, then fine tune up or down, looking across the AOs to help you.

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Question 5 Paper 1

This is the other question based on unseen, untaught texts. This time it involves comparing two love poems, corresponding with the Paper 1 context of love through the ages. This paper also involves study of three taught texts about love: a Shakespeare play, a novel and an anthology of poetry. This teaching will have established a familiarity with the subject matters and themes of Love through the ages, upon which students can draw.

To answer the question, the student needs to address the **question focus** through the lens of the **given view** by looking closely at relevant material from the texts concerned. Again, in this example question, the word **significance** is used to stimulate debate.

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Question 5 Paper 1

Compare and contrast the significance of ending a relationship in the following love poems.

(See the text of 'Since there's no help, come let us kiss and part' by Michael Drayton and 'The Terrible Door' by Harold Monro)

Question focus: ending a relationship
Given view: significance?

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Activity: Question 5 Paper 1, Student F

Please see Student F's response on page 43 in the Pre-event marking booklet.

To mark the response here, concentrate on the **generic marking grid** and make an accurate **holistic** judgement:

- Consider how well the student addresses the given view and question focus.
- Consider how closely and selectively they examine the text.
- Decide on the 'best fit' band that applies.
- Go the middle mark, then fine tune up or down, looking across the AOs to help you.

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Activity: Question 5 Paper 1, Student G

Please see Student G's response on page 46 in the Pre-event marking booklet.

To mark the response here, concentrate on the **generic marking grid** and make an accurate **holistic** judgement:

- Consider how well the student addresses the given view and question focus.
- Consider how closely and selectively they examine the text.
- Decide on the 'best fit' band that applies.
- Go the middle mark, then fine tune up or down, looking across the AOs to help you.

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Question 6 Paper 1

This final section of Paper 1 involves a choice of Questions 6 or 7. Both are generic, enabling the student to compare their centre's choice of poetry anthology with their centre's chosen novel. Again, the theme of Love through the ages is in focus and students are instructed to compare.

To answer the question, the student needs to address the **question focus** through the lens of the **given view** by looking closely at relevant material from the texts concerned. In this example question, there is a quoted given view. In other examples it may be a reported view or the word **significance** to stimulate debate.

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Question 6 Paper 1

'In the literature of love, opposites attract.'

In the light of this view, compare how lovers and their attraction to one another is presented in two texts you have studied.

You must write about at least two poems in your answer as well as the prose text you have studied.

Question focus: lovers' attraction
Given view: opposites attract

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Activity: Question 6 Paper 1, Student H

Please see Student H's response on page 53 in the Pre-event marking booklet.

To mark the response here, concentrate on the **generic marking grid** and make an accurate **holistic** judgement:

- Consider how well the student addresses the given view and question focus.
- Consider how closely and selectively they examine the text.
- Decide on the 'best fit' band that applies.
- Go the middle mark, then fine tune up or down, looking across the AOs to help you.

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Question 12 Paper 2B

This final section of Paper 2 is the second part of Section B, a generic question enabling the student to compare their centre's choice of the two remaining genres. This student opted for drama as their Section A text, so here the student must now compare prose and poetry. Again, the shared context of Modern times, literature from 1945 to the present day is in focus.

To answer the question, the student needs to: address the **question focus** through the lens of the **given view** (which is the same as in the first part of section B) by looking closely at relevant material from the texts concerned. In this example question, the word significance is used once more to encouraged debate and engagement with interpretation.

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Question 12 Paper 2B

Compare the significance of loneliness and social isolation in two other texts you have studied.

Remember to include in your answer reference to how meanings are shaped in the texts you are comparing.

You must use one prose text and one poetry text in your response, at least one of which must be a text written post-2000.

You must write about at least two poems.

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Activity: Question 12 Paper 2B, Student I

Please see Student I's response on page 60 in the Pre-event marking booklet.

To mark the response here, concentrate on the **generic marking grid** and make an accurate **holistic** judgement:

- Consider how well the student addresses the given view and question focus.
- Consider how closely and selectively they examine the text.
- Decide on the 'best fit' band that applies.
- Go the middle mark, then fine tune up or down, looking across the AOs to help you.

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Any questions?



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- A-level English Literature A: Getting started
- A-level English Literature A: Preparing for 2025 (Paper 1) (on demand)

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- Students of all ages and abilities are rewarded with a certificate every time they complete a short unit of learning, covering virtually any subject, topic or interest.
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Event materials

The content of this training course contains no reference to future exam content as far as we know at the time of production (summer 2025).

The electronic materials from this event will be available to download shortly. If you can't download them, they will be available in the customer portal of our online booking system after this event.

Once we receive notification that you have attended the course, you will be sent a certificate of attendance email. When you receive the email, please log in to your account and the materials will be available on the 'my resources' tab on the welcome screen.

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Learning outcomes

- Develop a greater understanding of how to apply the mark scheme
- Apply accuracy when identifying a level/awarding a mark
- Identify typical features and characteristics of responses at different levels/marks
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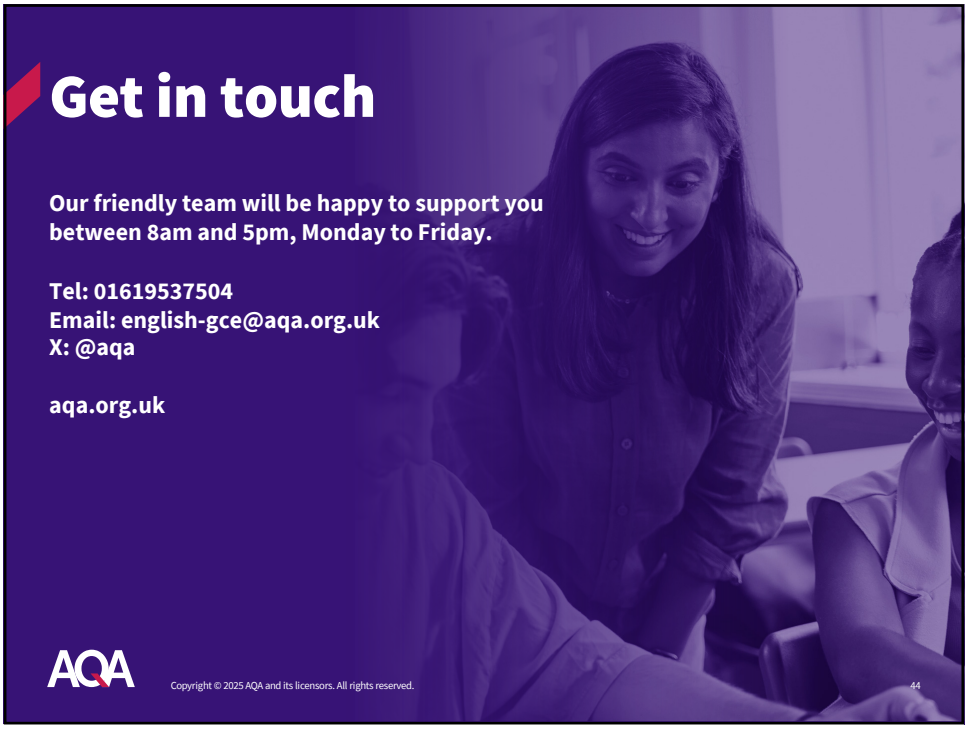
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Get in touch

Our friendly team will be happy to support you between 8am and 5pm, Monday to Friday.

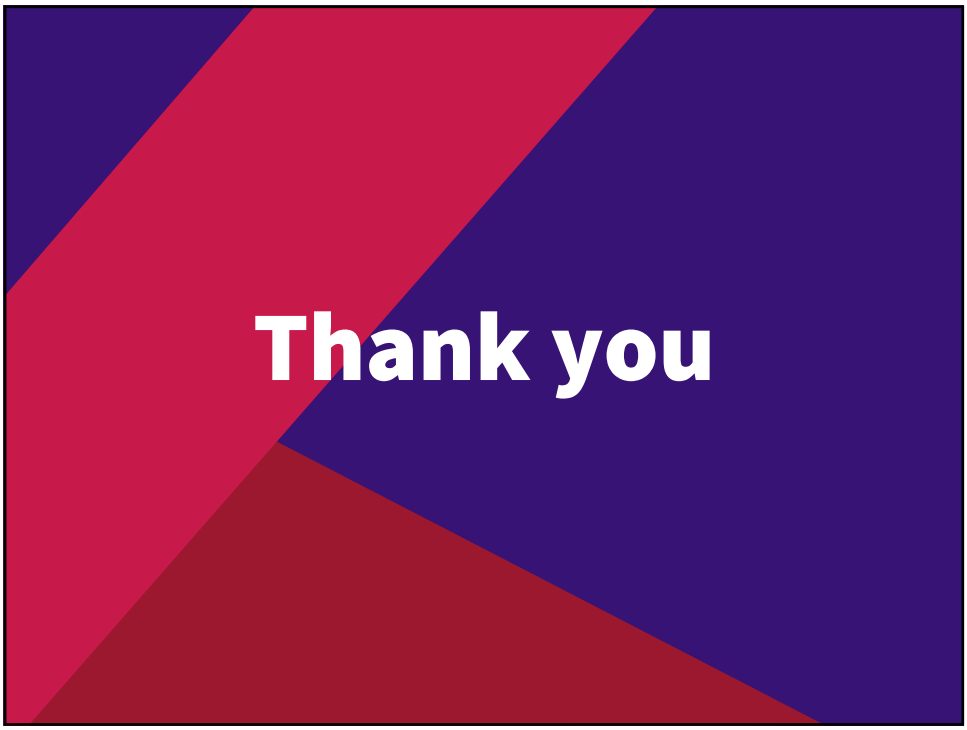
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